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DIPLOMA: INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

Subject: : **Business Analysis 3 Module 2/ Business Analysis 3.2**

Subject code : **AIBUY3A**

Assessment : **Project**

Date issued : **13 July 2025**

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Total Marks : **100**

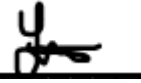
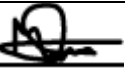
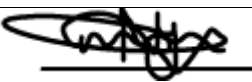
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AI-SOLUTION: Mental Health-bot

AI-Solution: Relevance to Theme

The Fourth Industrial Revolution is widely discussed, yet meaningful impacts on vulnerable populations remain rare. In many developing countries, significant barriers limit access to mental health support, despite technological advancements. This proposed solution utilizes Artificial Intelligence to create a chatbot that engages in empathetic conversations, classifies mental health symptoms, and guides users to suitable care.

Problem Definition

Mental health issues, particularly depression, are on the rise globally. However, access to mental health professionals remains limited, especially in underdeveloped regions. Long waiting times, financial constraints, and social stigma further prevent individuals from seeking timely help. As a result, many cases of depression go undiagnosed until advanced stages, leading to reduced productivity, social challenges, and, in severe cases, suicidal behaviour.

Lack of accessible, affordable, and early depression screening tools is the main cause. Existing healthcare facilities are often overwhelmed, leaving individuals without timely support.

This solution is highly relevant to the theme, as it leverages AI to address critical societal and economic problems in the healthcare industry. It is an AI-first product designed to scale a service that is constrained by human resources.

This AI chatbot supports municipalities by identifying urgent mental health issues and directing individuals to professional help when necessary. It reduces unnecessary clinic visits and alleviates the burden on healthcare professionals, while minimizing the need for new facilities. The service enables early detection and raises awareness, requiring minimal infrastructure investment and delivering immediate, confidential assistance to vulnerable community members.

Main Objectives

Our main goal is to design and implement an AI-powered Mental Health Chatbot that:

- Receives user input (symptoms, feelings, or mental state descriptions).
- Uses NLP and Machine Learning to classify the input into possible categories like depression, anxiety, stress, etc.
- Provides safe next steps (self-care strategies, stress management tips) and directs high-risk users to professional resources or emergency contacts.
- Preserves privacy, promotes awareness, and reduces stigma around mental health.

Business Objectives

- Provide a low-cost AI chatbot for early depression screening that is available 24/7 to individuals who cannot afford traditional therapy.
- Reduce the number of non-critical visits to healthcare facilities.
- Enhance early intervention rates by providing accessible AI-driven support, identifying users at high risk of severe distress or crisis, and effectively referring them to human resources.
- Aim for measurable reductions in symptoms of mental health issues such as anxiety and depression among consistent users, thus empowering individuals to manage their well-being through tailored advice.
- Offer anonymous support to reduce stigma barriers.

Business Background

The Fourth Industrial Revolution is widely discussed, but its real-world impact remains limited for vulnerable populations. Mental health disorders affect around 1.1 billion people globally, with 75% in low-income countries receiving no treatment. The COVID-19 pandemic triggered an increase in mental health issues worldwide. Traditional mental health care faces barriers like high cost, long waiting times, limited geographical access, and social stigma.

Business success criteria

- More than 80% user satisfaction rate from feedback surveys.
- Average 35% reduction in self-reported anxiety/depression scores after 3 weeks of consistent use.
- Achieve a monthly active user rate of 65% and an average of 4 sessions per week per user.
- Maintain more than 85% success rate in detecting and properly referring high-risk phrases (e.g, suicidal ideas) by providing immediate relevant help line information.
- 90% system availability
- Response time under 10 seconds per query
- 40% reduction in emergency mental health crises

Requirements

- Python 3.8+
- Transformers library (Hugging Face)
- Flask/FastAPI for web interface
- NLTK/spaCy for text processing
- Natural conversation flow
- Crisis detection and escalation
- Resource recommendation
- Session management

Constraints

- Cannot provide medical diagnosis or replace human therapists
- Limited to text-based interactions initially
- Requires careful ethical handling of sensitive data
- Must comply with healthcare data protection regulations
- Requires continuous monitoring by human clinical oversight

Risks & Mitigation

- **Risks:**
 - Misinterpretation of user emotions and misdiagnosis
 - Data privacy concerns
 - Over-reliance on AI
 - Technical failure
- **Mitigation:**
 - Multiple validation layers, clear disclaimers, and human escalation
 - Anonymous data handling, consent, and encryption
 - Session limits and professional referrals
 - Regular backups and monitoring

Initial Assessment of Tools & Techniques

- Python for implementation
- Pandas, Scikit-learn for data processing and modelling
- GitHub for project management
- TensorFlow for Machine Learning Framework

- NLP for understanding user input

AI Solution

Python-based chatbot with:

- Natural language understanding for mental health contexts
- Sentiment analysis to detect distress levels
- Crisis detection algorithm with escalation protocol
- CBT-based exercise suggestions
- Resource referral system
- Web interface for accessible usage built with Flask/Streamlit

Machine Learning Approach:

- Model trained on a depression dataset with demographic, lifestyle, and mental health indicators.
- BERT: State-of-the-art for understanding context and intent in mental health conversations
- CNN-LSTM: Effective for sequential emotion analysis in text

Data:

Dataset: final_depression_dataset_1.csv

Includes features such as Age, Gender, Work/Study status, Sleep Duration, Dietary Habits, Suicidal Thoughts, Family History of Mental Illness, etc.

Target variable: Depression (Yes/No).

Model:

- Accuracy: 97% (based on test data).
- The confusion matrix shows balanced performance across classes.
- Ensures reliability in real-world use.

Solution Techniques:

- Handling missing values: Simple imputation (if required).
- Classification: Random Forest.
- NLP: Chatbot interface that interacts with users, collects input, and maps to model features.
- Accuracy Improvement Strategies: Active learning from user feedback.

Continuous retraining with new conversation data

- Real-time monitoring and logging

Natural Language Processing:

- Named Entity Recognition for identifying locations, names (to anonymize)
- Sentiment Analysis for emotional state tracking
- Topic Modelling for conversation theme identification
- Text Summarization for session reports
- Emotion Recognition: Detecting anxiety, depression, panic from text patterns

Deep Learning Architecture:

Specific Deep Learning Techniques:

- Transformer Architecture: Base for understanding conversation context

- Convolutional Neural Networks: For pattern recognition in emotional expressions
- Long Short-Term Memory: For maintaining conversation context
- Attention Mechanisms: For focusing on critical phrases indicating a crisis

Applications:

- Real-time emotion trajectory tracking during conversations
- Personalized response generation based on user history
- Predictive modelling for mental health deterioration
- Adaptive intervention strategies based on user engagement

Practical Solution

We developed a working Python-based chatbot that:

- Asks users relevant lifestyle and mental health questions.
- Processes their responses into structured input.
- Predicts depression risk using the trained Random Forest model.
- Provides feedback: either reassurance and self-care tips (for “No Depression”) or referral advice (for “Depression”).

This practical demonstration illustrates how AI can help reduce barriers to mental healthcare and facilitate early detection.

Conclusion:

This project demonstrates how AI can contribute to the healthcare industry by addressing mental health challenges. The proposed chatbot provides early depression screening, reduces clinic overload, and empowers individuals to manage their well-being. It is a scalable, low-cost solution that aligns with the 4IR vision of utilizing AI for societal benefit.

Reference:

- Dataset: *final_depression_dataset_1.csv*
- Scikit-learn documentation: <https://scikit-learn.org>
- WHO Depression Fact Sheet: <https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/depression>
- Textbook: Tutorials Point Pty. Ltd. (2016). Artificial Intelligence with Python Tutorial. Tutorials Point.